FIELD GUIDE / VISUAL AUDIT

AI-GENERATED WEBSITES & WEB APPS

How to recognise generic visual patterns, design shortcuts and unfinished interfaces.

THE CENTRAL RULE

Appearance can reveal generic design.

It cannot prove who or what built it.

Research-informed guide | Updated 28 October 2026

For designers, buyers and product reviewers

Executive summary

What you are trying to spot: not AI itself, but design that appears to have been produced from a generic pattern without enough product-specific thinking, review or refinement. AI can also create excellent, distinctive work, and people can create generic work without AI.

Keep these three questions in mind
1. Could this design belong to almost any business?
2. Does every section use the same visual formula?
3. Does the interface still make sense when real content and interactions are involved?

The evidence ladder

CLUE LEVEL	EXAMPLES	WHAT IT CAN TELL YOU
Weak	Purple gradients, large sans-serif headlines, round buttons, a popular font, three feature cards.	A familiar style is being used. These are common design conventions, not evidence of AI by themselves.
Moderate	The same layout repeated across sections, abstract imagery replacing product proof, generic brand language, weak visual hierarchy.	The design may be generic, under-tailored or insufficiently art-directed.
Strong quality warning	Inconsistent pages, clipped mobile layouts, strange states, broken feedback, inaccessible controls, obvious placeholder data.	The work may not have been carefully reviewed. It still does not prove AI authorship.
Direct evidence	A disclosed workflow, build logs, source history or reliable documentation about how the product was created.	Can support attribution. Visual appearance alone generally cannot.

Why this guide is structured this way

A 2026 systematic review of 20 peer-reviewed studies found that generative no-code tools can produce plausible interfaces, but can also show variable output, homogenized layouts, consistency problems and incomplete accessibility. A 2026 practitioner guide from OpenAI similarly notes that underspecified prompts can fall back on common patterns and lead to generic structure or weak hierarchy. These findings support using multiple clues rather than one visual stereotype. [1, 2]

Bottom line: use this document to assess visual originality and product quality. Do not use it to accuse a designer or vendor of using AI without independent evidence.

Quick scan: 12 recurring visual clues

Use this page for a fast first impression. One or two clues are normal in modern design systems. Patterns become more meaningful when several appear together and the site lacks product-specific detail.

1. Formulaic hero
A centred headline, small eyebrow pill, one highlighted word, two CTAs and a soft glow.

2. Gradient overload
Purple-blue backgrounds, gradient text, glows or blurred colour blobs used without a brand reason.

3. Repeated three-card rows
The same three equal cards show up in multiple sections even when the content differs.

4. Everything boxed
Features, metrics, navigation, charts, content and forms all become rounded cards.

5. Abstract product art
Spheres, cubes or floating mock dashboards replace a real product or real-world context.

6. Stock visual language
Generic polished imagery, generic AI faces, mismatched illustration styles or synthetic-looking scenes.

7. Default typography formula
Oversized bold sans-serif, one gradient word, uppercase labels and identical heading rhythms.

8. Icon decoration
Emojis, sparkles and line icons are added where they do not clarify meaning or action.

9. Repetitive sections
Every section has the same centred headline, short paragraph, card grid and button.

10. Generic proof
Large round numbers, identical testimonials or trust claims with no details or verification.

11. Weak brand identity
Removing the logo and company name leaves a page that could represent almost any product.

12. Micro-element clutter
Too many chips, pills, badges, tiny labels, floating callouts or competing CTAs.

Fast rule: do not count the ingredients in isolation. Ask whether they serve the customer, the product and the story. A three-card layout can be right for comparing three plans; it is weaker when used automatically for everything.

Marketing websites: the first impression

1. The familiar AI landing-page composition

A small capsule label sits above a large centred headline. One word is coloured or given a gradient. A short sentence follows, then two rounded calls to action. The background often has a glow or abstract shape. This pattern is common because it is easy to produce and can look polished quickly. It becomes a warning sign when the layout has no clear connection to the business.

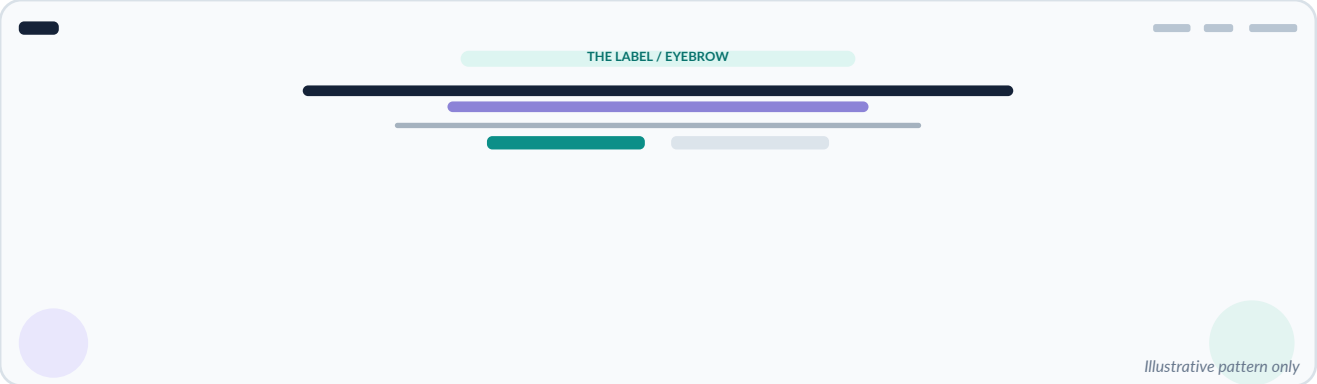


Illustration: a common composition pattern, not a screenshot and not proof that a page was AI-generated.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHY IT MAY BE A WARNING	WHAT TO ASK
A headline could promote any company.	The design may have been chosen before the business and audience were understood.	What specific customer problem does the hero communicate?
Two equally prominent buttons.	The primary action is unclear or both actions compete.	What is the single most important next step?
Floating badges, stat strips and mini cards around the headline.	Decoration competes with the key message.	Would removing these improve clarity?
The brand name is small while the generic claim dominates.	The brand may be visually interchangeable.	Would a first-time visitor remember this brand?

2. Gradients, glows and glass effects

Purple-blue gradients, blurred orbs, translucent glass panels, soft shadows and neon outlines can be used well. Be cautious when many effects are layered at once, when the page has no clear visual anchor, or when the style clashes with the category. A luxury service, local retailer, logistics tool and enterprise finance app do not need the same atmosphere.

3. Typography that follows a formula

Watch for unusually oversized bold text, one accent-coloured word in every headline, uppercase eyebrow labels above every section, and the same font treatment across all information. Common fonts such as Inter, Roboto or Arial are not proof of AI; the warning is a lack of typographic intent and hierarchy. [2, 3]

Marketing websites: deeper visual signals

4. The repeated-card problem

A common shortcut is to turn every concept into a rounded rectangle with an icon, title and two lines of copy. Check whether cards are used for features, customer quotes, statistics, use cases, process steps, product benefits and calls to action. If everything has the same container and visual weight, the page becomes monotonous and makes it hard to tell what matters most.

5. Imagery that does not explain the product

- Abstract shapes instead of evidence: glowing spheres, cubes or random 3D objects are used as the main visual even though the product is practical and concrete.
- Generic stock photography: the people or scenes do not resemble the audience, setting or actual work.
- Generated-image artifacts: nonsensical text, inconsistent reflections, strange object details or impossible visual relationships. These can suggest AI-generated imagery, not necessarily an AI-built website.
- Style mismatch: photographs, icons, illustrations and screenshots look like they came from unrelated visual systems.

6. Repetition across the whole page

Scroll beyond the hero. Look for the same heading placement, copy length, three-column grid, pale background strip and button in every section. Good design repeats its rules, but varies composition to suit the information. A process may need a diagram; a product may need a real screenshot; pricing may need a comparison table; a customer story may need a detailed quote or result.

7. Generic trust signals

Be alert to identical testimonial cards, round statistics without context, generic profile portraits, vague badges and statements such as “trusted by thousands” with no names, dates, methods or details. This is a credibility warning rather than an AI fingerprint. Do not assume a claim is false solely because the design looks templated.

8. Visual overproduction and clutter

Pill clusters, tiny status labels, floating callouts, decorative icons and multiple competing CTAs can make a page feel assembled from UI components rather than composed around a clear message. The opposite failure also occurs: excessive empty space, a tiny amount of useful content and an oversized hero make a thin page appear more substantial than it is.

Brand replacement test
Remove the logo, name and colour accent in your mind. Could this still be the homepage of five unrelated companies? If yes, the page may be relying on a familiar template more than on a distinct brand idea.

Web apps: what to inspect after the homepage

Web apps include dashboards, CRMs, admin panels, marketplaces, booking systems and internal tools. Their visual quality is tested across many states, not just the first screen. Generated interfaces may look strong in a screenshot but become inconsistent when users search, edit, filter, submit or encounter an error.

AREA	POSSIBLE WARNING SIGNS	WHAT A STRONGER INTERFACE DOES
Dashboard	Every number sits in a card; too many equally important metrics; no clear reading order.	Puts the most useful work first, groups related information and makes priority visible.
Navigation	Active page is unclear; menu labels are vague; navigation changes across pages.	Keeps locations, labels and selected states consistent.
Charts	Charts lack units, time periods or source context; colours do not match the legend; data looks like decoration.	Shows what is measured, when, and why it matters for a decision.
Tables	Columns are cramped; sample rows repeat; labels do not match values; everything is converted into cards.	Supports scanning, comparison, filtering and predictable row actions.
Forms	Field sizes vary without reason; labels are vague; error messages are missing or appear far from the field.	Explains what is needed, what went wrong and how to fix it.
Empty states	A blank area or unexplained “no data” message appears when a new user has no records.	Explains why it is empty and offers a relevant first action.
Loading / errors	Endless spinner, silent failure, inconsistent alerts, or a broken layout after an error.	Gives timely status, recovery steps and consistent feedback.
Responsive layout	Sidebar, modal or table overflows on mobile; buttons are clipped; content needs two-way scrolling unnecessarily.	Reflows or adapts controls to the available screen while preserving essential tasks.

The “everything is a card” pattern

Cards are useful when they group a coherent object or interactive action. They become visual noise when every region gets the same border, shadow and radius. Operational tools often benefit from calm surfaces, good spacing, strong labels, useful tables and restrained accent colours rather than a mosaic of decorative panels. [2, 3]

Consistency, responsiveness and accessibility

These checks are especially valuable because many defects are invisible in a polished desktop screenshot. They are signs of weak review or implementation quality; they are not proof that AI was used.

Design consistency

- ☐ The same primary action looks like a filled button on one page and a text link on another without a clear reason.
- ☐ Border radii, shadow strength, field heights, heading sizes or spacing rules vary unexpectedly.
- ☐ The selected navigation item is obvious on one screen but invisible on another.
- ☐ One page uses a different icon family or illustration style from the rest of the product.
- ☐ A modal, dropdown or toast uses a different visual language from the application around it.

Responsive behaviour

- ☐ Headlines wrap into awkward single words or collide with nearby elements on narrow screens.
- ☐ Buttons shrink until their labels are difficult to read or tap.
- ☐ Images crop out the important subject or keep desktop proportions that waste mobile space.
- ☐ Fixed banners, cookie notices, chat widgets or floating actions cover essential content.
- ☐ Wide tables force unnecessary horizontal scrolling or hide critical information.
- ☐ A desktop sidebar is simply squeezed onto mobile instead of being adapted.

Accessibility checks with visible consequences

- ☐ Text is too low-contrast against its background, especially inside gradient buttons or over images.
- ☐ Colour is the only way to distinguish success, warning, failure or chart categories.
- ☐ Keyboard focus is hard to see, or interactive controls have no obvious focus state.
- ☐ Forms use placeholder text as the only label, making fields difficult to understand after typing.
- ☐ Animation continues when a user has requested reduced motion, or motion distracts from the task.

Useful benchmarks

WCAG 2.2 includes a minimum contrast ratio of 4.5:1 for ordinary text and requires reflow without loss of information at a width equivalent to 320 CSS pixels, subject to defined exceptions. These are measurable accessibility criteria, not style preferences. A visual review can flag likely issues, but formal conformance needs proper testing. [4]

A repeatable 10-minute inspection

Use the same procedure every time you review a site. It reduces snap judgements and makes comparisons between vendors or products more fair.

1. **00:00 to 01:00 | First viewport**
   Look at the logo, headline, visual anchor, main action and spacing. Ask whether the message and brand are immediately specific.
2. **01:00 to 02:30 | Scroll the full page**
   Notice whether every section repeats the same layout, cards, background colour or call-to-action pattern.
3. **02:30 to 04:00 | Inspect the imagery**
   Check whether visuals show the real product, audience or environment. Flag abstract decoration that does not explain anything.
4. **04:00 to 05:30 | Open two other pages**
   Compare typography, navigation, buttons, spacing, footer and page-specific layouts. A site should feel like one system.
5. **05:30 to 07:00 | Change screen width**
   Inspect a narrow mobile viewport. Look for overflow, clipped actions, bad cropping and unreadable text.
6. **07:00 to 08:30 | Interact**
   Try search, navigation, a form, a filter, a menu or an obvious primary action. Look for feedback, loading and error states.
7. **08:30 to 09:30 | Check credibility**
   Test whether claims, numbers, testimonials and product screens are specific and verifiable.
8. **09:30 to 10:00 | Score and record**
   Score the generic-design signals, capture concrete examples and separate observations from assumptions about authorship.

Write observations, not accusations.
Good note: “The landing page repeats the same three-card block five times and does not show the product.”
Poor note: “This was definitely made by AI.”

Visual warning scorecard

Score each category 0, 1 or 2. The score measures how generic the design appears, not whether AI was involved. Keep notes beside the score so another reviewer can understand your reasoning.

CATEGORY	0 - LOW	1 - SOME	2 - STRONG	SCORE
Generic hero	Message and visual are specific.	Some familiar elements.	Could fit almost any company.	___ / 2
Visual effects	Effects are restrained and useful.	Some decorative overload.	Glows, gradients and glass effects dominate.	___ / 2
Card repetition	Layout varies to fit content.	A few repeated grids.	Most sections are the same card pattern.	___ / 2
Imagery	Shows the product or context.	Mix of specific and generic imagery.	Abstract or stock imagery replaces evidence.	___ / 2
Design consistency	Rules are clear across pages.	Minor inconsistencies.	Components and pages feel assembled from different systems.	___ / 2
Product specificity	Language and layouts fit a real audience.	Some generic sections.	Could be reused for many unrelated businesses.	___ / 2

TOTAL	HOW TO INTERPRET IT	NEXT STEP
0-3 / 12	Few generic-design signals were observed.	Still test usability, mobile behaviour and real content.
4-7 / 12	Several generic patterns are present.	Ask for brand rationale, real product screens and more page-specific compositions.
8-12 / 12	Strong generic-design pattern.	Review originality and product fit. Record evidence and avoid conclusions about authorship.

Additional issue log

PAGE / STATE	OBSERVED ISSUE	IMPACT

Important: do not compare scores as if they were a validated AI detector. The scale is a practical internal rubric created for this guide.

What “generic” looks like by business type

A layout is not bad simply because it follows a convention. The real test is whether its visuals, information and interactions serve the actual customer journey.

BUSINESS TYPE	WEAK / GENERIC SIGNAL	MORE PRODUCT-SPECIFIC DIRECTION
E-commerce store	Abstract hero art, fake product thumbnails, repeated feature cards and no clear product category or purchase flow.	Real product photography, useful filters, pricing, delivery and returns information, mobile-first browsing and checkout clarity.
Ghanaian retailer / fashion	Generic luxury stock photos and identical editorial layout regardless of the actual collection.	Real inventory, local customer context, accurate sizing, payment and delivery details, clear WhatsApp or checkout path where appropriate.
Logistics / freight	Floating cubes and tech gradients instead of showing shipment tracking, milestones and proof of status.	Tracking number entry, shipment stages, estimates, notifications, documentation and a clear exception-handling path.
Fintech / financial app	Decorative graphs, unexplained money metrics, neon effects and vague “financial freedom” claims.	Readable balances, dates, fees, transaction status, confirmation steps, risk notices and clear recovery from errors.
CRM / operations tool	A marketing-style hero inside the dashboard, a mosaic of cards and poor support for tables or repeated tasks.	Clear navigation, useful data density, filters, bulk actions, accessible forms and obvious status feedback.
Restaurant / hospitality	Generic food imagery, fake ratings, no menu detail and booking buttons with no next-step clarity.	Real menu or room imagery, prices, location, availability, booking or order path, and accurate policy details.

A practical test for every sector

Ask: “What real information does this customer need to make the next decision?” Then see whether the visual design makes that information easier to find, compare or act on. If the artwork gets more attention than the useful information, the page may be visually polished but strategically weak.

How to reduce the “AI-generated” look

If you are building websites or web apps with AI, the answer is not to ban gradients, cards, popular fonts or animation. The answer is to make deliberate choices and test the output against the real product.

1. Start with the customer and the job

Define who the product serves, what they need to do and what decision the page should support. A fashion store and a finance dashboard should not share a visual strategy just because both use React.

2. Define a visual direction before building

Choose a clear design idea, a small colour system, typography roles, spacing rules, image style and interaction principles. Provide references, but explain what to take from them and what not to copy. [2, 3]

3. Show the real product

Use real products, screenshots, workflows, customer environments, data and examples wherever possible. Do not use abstract technology art as a substitute for product evidence.

4. Give each section one job

Make a section explain, prove, compare, demonstrate or convert. Choose a layout that fits that job instead of repeating three cards by default.

5. Use cards only when they help

Use a card to group a meaningful object or action. Otherwise try a plain layout, table, divider, list, image, diagram or open space.

6. Make the brand recognisable

Give the page one distinctive visual anchor: photography, colour, typography, composition, a product detail or a repeatable brand device. A logo alone cannot make a generic page distinctive.

7. Write specific copy

Replace vague claims such as “unlock growth” with clear outcomes, real constraints, actual examples and evidence. Remove placeholder figures and invented testimonials.

8. Build every state

Design the empty state, loading state, successful action, validation error, failed request and permission denial. These states are part of the product, not optional decoration.

9. Check multiple screens

Inspect desktop, tablet and mobile widths. Review real content, long names, long numbers, translation growth and unusual data. Fix overlap and layout changes before calling the design finished.

10. Review with a human

Ask someone unfamiliar with the project to complete a real task. Record where they hesitate. Use their feedback to revise the hierarchy, language and flow.

Build principle
AI is useful for speed and exploration. Human review provides judgement, context, taste, verification and accountability. The goal is not to hide AI assistance. It is to ship a design that fits the product and works for its users.

Printable review checklist

Use this page when reviewing a vendor deliverable, a competitor website, a new web app or your own AI-assisted build. Check observations, not assumptions.

A. First impression

- ☐ The brand and target audience are clear without reading every paragraph.
- ☐ The main headline explains a specific value or task rather than a vague promise.
- ☐ The primary action is visually clear and not competing with several equal actions.
- ☐ The main visual shows product, people, context or evidence that matters.

B. Visual design

- ☐ Colours, gradients, shadows and animation have a clear purpose.
- ☐ Typography has a clear hierarchy and remains readable at different sizes.
- ☐ Cards, pills, icons and badges are used only when they improve understanding.
- ☐ Sections vary based on their content rather than repeating one formula.
- ☐ Images and illustrations look consistent and relevant to the brand.

C. Content and trust

- ☐ Testimonials, statistics, logos and claims are specific and supportable.
- ☐ The copy uses real product language and avoids repeated generic phrases.
- ☐ No placeholder data or fake visual content remains in the delivered product.

D. Web app behaviour

- ☐ Navigation, buttons, forms, filters and menus behave as expected.
- ☐ Loading, success, empty and error states are clear.
- ☐ Tables and charts show labels, units, context and meaningful values.
- ☐ Visual rules remain consistent across pages and states.

E. Mobile and accessibility

- ☐ Content reflows cleanly on narrow screens without avoidable two-way scrolling.
- ☐ Text has sufficient contrast and is not clipped or too small.
- ☐ Keyboard focus and control states are visible.
- ☐ Colour is not the only way information is communicated.
- ☐ Fixed elements do not cover content or actions.

Review notes

Page or feature: _____

Most important issue: _____

Evidence / screenshot reference: _____

Recommended next step: _____

Sources and further reading

The guide combines peer-reviewed research, official accessibility standards, usability guidance and practitioner material. The sources support the principles and observations; none provides a universal visual test that proves AI authorship.

[1] Irmak, G. & Mahmoud, Q. H. (2026). Design Behaviour and Interface Consistency in Generative No-Code Tools: A Systematic Literature Review. Computers, 15(4), 238. Published 12 April 2026.
https://www.mdpi.com/2073-431X/15/4/238
Peer-reviewed review of 20 studies covering layout, visual consistency, usability, accessibility and reproducibility in generative no-code systems.

[2] OpenAI Developers (2026). Designing delightful frontends with GPT-5.4. Published 20 March 2026.
https://developers.openai.com/blog/designing-delightful-frontends-with-gpt-5-4
Practitioner guidance explaining how underspecified prompts can lead to common patterns, generic structure and weak hierarchy, plus methods for improving specificity and verification.

[3] OpenAI API Docs (current page at time of writing). Frontend prompt instructions.
https://developers.openai.com/api/docs/guides/frontend-prompt
Guidance on tailoring frontends to user needs and domains, keeping operational apps focused, consistent and useful.

[4] World Wide Web Consortium (W3C). Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.2.
https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG22/
Official accessibility standard, including contrast, reflow, keyboard accessibility, focus visibility and other measurable criteria.

[5] Nielsen Norman Group. 10 Usability Heuristics for User Interface Design. Updated 30 January 2024.
https://www.nngroup.com/articles/ten-usability-heuristics/
Established usability principles including visibility of system status, consistency, error prevention, recognition and minimalist design.

[6] Design with Claude (2026). How accessible is AI-generated UI? Study updated July 2026.
https://www.designwithclaude.com/design-research/ai-generated-frontends
A practitioner audit of 123 public frontends attributed to AI coding tools. Useful as a directional audit, not a representative estimate of all AI-built sites.

Scope and limits

The visual indicators in this document are a practical synthesis rather than a validated forensic detector. The research base on the visual “signature” of AI-generated websites is still developing. Existing studies often focus on interface quality, usability and accessibility rather than proving authorship from screenshots. A website can be AI-assisted and excellent, or human-built and generic. To attribute authorship confidently, seek independent evidence such as disclosure, build records, source history or direct documentation.

Recommended standards for real reviews

- Apply WCAG 2.2 criteria for accessibility instead of relying only on visual impressions.
- Use the Nielsen Norman Group heuristics to assess feedback, consistency, error prevention and clarity.
- Use real user tasks to test whether people can complete the job, not merely whether the first screen looks polished.

Remember: a website should be judged by its fit to the audience, clarity of its visual hierarchy, credibility of its content, consistency across states and ability to help people complete real tasks.